Probabilistic Performance Guarantees for Unseen Service Compositions and Configurations

Boris Sedlak, *Member, IEEE*, Milos Gravara, *Member, IEEE*, Víctor Casamayor Pujol, *Member, IEEE*, Stefan Nastic, *Member, IEEE*, Schahram Dustdar, *Fellow, IEEE*

***Abstract*—**

***Index Terms*—Performance Guarantees, Service Quality, Gaussian Processes, Performance Modeling, Service Composition**

I. Introduction

Large Language Models (LLMs) have risen as universal interpretation and generation engines for text-based contents, introducing a major disruption for software development [5]. Traditionally, computing services were developed manually according to stakeholder requirements, and operated in close-loop controls to continuously meet operational thresholds. Within that context, LLMs appeared as a fast and cost-efficient enabler for autonomous software development and deployment, opening a new branch of service research [1]: automatic generation [4], [12] and recomposition [18] of software services. The combined vision from these works is clear: a *future internet*, where agents aim to continuously satisfy high-level user intents by generating, composing, and reconfiguring software applications and their services.

Traditional service-oriented architectures already provide clear roles and interfaces to operate such systems [19]: the service provider and the service consumer establish Service Level Agreements (SLAs) that specify the expected quality through measurable Service Level Objectives (SLOs). In this future internet, applications will be tailored to individual clients and their SLOs [21]. However, creating this vast space of possible application also means that potential compositions or configurations will often lack end-to-end benchmarks *prior to deployment*. It is neither possible nor cost-efficient to benchmark this search space exhaustively before offering a solution to a consumer; hence, service providers require predictive models for estimating the quality of different service compositions and configurations before deployment.

Applications themselves can be recomposed into systems of systems [17]; to decrease the overall complexity, individual systems must provide clear interfaces and guarantees. So suppose we need to ensure that one system's latency is below a threshold, it is not enough to *estimate* that the tail latency (e.g., the P_{99} percentile) will be below the threshold, but the application must *guarantee* this with a certain likelihood. To avoid SLA violations, providers could simply give increasingly conservative performance estimates, which could only be fulfilled by provisioning more resources, increasing the price for the consumer, and wasting the provider's resources. The challenge is thus to make the performance guarantee as *tight* as possible. For a service composition S, also called an application, with topology $\{s_1 \rightarrow s_2 \rightarrow \dots\}$, a provider needs to be able to accurately answer the following questions:

- What performance could we guaranteed for this application, before conducting any end-to-end benchmark?
- What performance could we guarantee if we replaced a service (e.g., s_1) with another one (e.g., s_x) that was not benchmarked end-to-end in this exact application?
- What performance could we guarantee if we reconfigured an individual service (e.g., s_1) to a configuration that was not benchmarked end-to-end in this application?

While composition and configuration are operationally decoupled—services can be reconfigured without altering the topology, and vice versa—they are logically entangled: estimating composite performance requires understanding individual service dynamics under limited empirical observations. Optimization techniques like branch-and-bound can reduce the candidate space, but evaluating candidate solutions remains the core bottleneck. Learning-based optimizers must contend with varying degrees of empirical evidence, ranging from well-observed service instances to completely unseen configurations and compositions.

TODO: Add summary paragraph introducing the contribution/solution: State the gap in existing work (e.g., deterministic code contracts vs. black-box microservices) and summarize the proposed PPG framework combining SVGPs and Stochastic Network Calculus.

II. Preliminaries

A. Motivating Example

Consider a customer that requests a real-time drone monitoring application, which can be structured as a four-stage pipeline: (1) video stream ingestion from the drone, (2) object detection along the trajectory, (3) trajectory adjustment calculation, and (4) telemetry reporting to an external traffic planner. Logically, this application is composed of distinct, chained microservices $S = \{s_1 \rightarrow s_2 \rightarrow s_3 \rightarrow s_4\}$.

Each service in this pipeline can be configured along multiple dimensions, such as allocated hardware resources (e.g., CPU cores r) and internal service parameters (e.g.,

B. Sedlak, P. Raith, A. Morichetta, and S. Dustdar are with the Distributed Systems Group, TU Wien, Vienna, Austria (e-mail: b.sedlak@dsg.tuwien.ac.at; p.raith@dsg.tuwien.ac.at; a.morichetta@dsg.tuwien.ac.at; dustdar@dsg.tuwien.ac.at).

V. Casamayor Pujol is with the Department of Engineering, Universitat Pompeu Fabra, Barcelona, Spain and S. Dustdar is with ICREA (e-mail: v.casamayor@upf.edu; schahram.dustdar@upf.edu).

object detection model resolution or batch size c). While these configuration knobs dictate execution time, the customer is solely interested in end-to-end *performance* (e.g., total latency $\leq 100\,\text{ms}$) and overall *cost* (e.g., minimize resources).

Furthermore, external systems like the traffic planner pose strict workload bounds (e.g., updates must arrive consistently every 100 ms). Adhering to these bounds in distributed systems typically relies on reporting high-percentile tail latencies (e.g., P_{90} or P_{99}). However, because this specific pipeline topology and configuration combination has never been executed and benchmarked end-to-end prior to deployment, relying on local empirical metrics introduces two major breakdowns:

1) *Non-additivity of tail percentiles:* Latency percentiles across pipeline stages do not add up linearly (i.e., $P_{99}(s_1 + s_2) \neq P_{99}(s_1) + P_{99}(s_2)$).
2) *Uncertainty under unseen states:* Point-estimate surrogate models fail to quantify epistemic uncertainty, leaving operators unable to distinguish between a service configuration that is guaranteed to perform well, one that reliably performs poorly, and one that is simply unobserved.

B. Research Challenges

TODO: This section is 50% autocompleted. I'd rather like two really strong challenges, as they had in Fluxion [16]. Maybe we can also combine with the motivating example.

To enable zero-shot performance estimation for arbitrary service compositions and configurations without exhaustive end-to-end benchmarking, a performance evaluation framework must satisfy four fundamental requirements:

Challenge #1: Rigorous Tail Guarantees. Point estimates and average-case predictions are insufficient for enforcing SLAs. The framework must derive formal, probabilistic tail-latency bounds (e.g., bounding the tail probability $\mathbb{P}(D > d) \leq \epsilon$) rather than relying on empirical target percentiles that can err unpredictably in either direction.

Challenge #2: Zero-Shot Composition under Data Sparsity. Because evaluating every candidate application topology and configuration through offline profiling is computationally infeasible, the framework must compose end-to-end guarantees purely from localized, single-service observations without requiring end-to-end empirical evidence of the target application.

Challenge #3: Queueing-Aware Workload Propagation. Real-world request loads fluctuate dynamically. Upstream services alter request dynamics—introducing jitter, burstiness, or batching—which directly affects downstream service execution. The model must explicitly capture parameterized workload propagation (e.g., arrival rate λ and burstiness) through queueing-aware abstractions.

Challenge #4: Uncertainty Quantification for Unseen States. When evaluating unseen service configurations, the performance model must decouple inherent runtime variability (aleatoric uncertainty) from model ignorance due to sparse empirical evidence (epistemic uncertainty). Quantifying epistemic variance is essential for distinguishing known poor configurations from unexplored ones, enabling downstream optimizers to safely balance performance, SLO risk, and adaptive evidence collection.

C. Background and Related Work

We group related work by how it obtains the performance of an application: (1) analytical models derive it from a formal description of the system, (2) learned models fit it to measurements of the entire application, and (3) compositional models assemble it from models of the individual services. For each group, we explain *how* it models performance and *why* it leaves the presented research challenges open.

1) Analytical Performance Models: Queueing theory is a classical tool for relating workload and capacity to response time [13]. For instance, Gandhi et al. [10] model the performance of individual servers as M/G/1 queues[1], and use this model for finding a power allocation that minimizes overall response time. Layered Queueing Networks [8] extend queueing networks to software services that hold one resource while waiting for another, as in nested client–server calls. Both target mean response times in steady state rather than tail probabilities (Challenge #1). Network calculus bounds delays instead of averaging them: Duan [3] describes network and compute services through latency–rate capability profiles, merges these profiles into one end-to-end profile, and derives the maximum delay of the composite service. This bound is deterministic, i.e., it covers the worst case and thus becomes overly conservative for services with variable execution times; Stochastic Network Calculus (SNC) [7], on which we build, instead bounds the *probability* of exceeding a given delay.

Closest in spirit, Iyer et al. [14] compute *performance contracts* for software network functions without executing them: symbolic analysis of the source code yields conservative upper bounds on the memory accesses and execution cycles per packet, expressed as functions of workload-dependent variables; contracts for chains of network functions are computed recursively. As with worst-case execution time analysis [24], this requires access to the source code, whereas microservices are typically deployed as opaque containers. Moreover, these contracts bound the processing effort per packet, not waiting time that accumulates under load (Challenge #3).

Common to all analytical models is that their parameters (e.g., service rates, branching probabilities, or code paths) must be supplied for the exact system under study. None of them expresses how reliable a prediction is for a configuration that was never measured (Challenge #4).

2) Learning Models of Entire Applications: A second line of work treats the application as one big black box and learns its end-to-end performance from empirical measurements; we call this the *top-down* approach. *Ernest* [23] fits a small parametric model to short profiling runs of an analytics job on samples of the input data, and extrapolates the running time to larger datasets and clusters. *CherryPick* [2] replaces the fixed model structure with a Gaussian Process (GP) and uses its

[1]Note that M implies a *Markovian* (or Poisson) arrival process, and G implies a *General* service process, i.e., one that can be described through a mean and variance. Note that *Pegasus* supports a wider range of arrival processes, but restricts the service process to be Gaussian distributed.

confidence intervals to choose the next cloud configuration to benchmark; the search stops as soon as the model can identify the best configuration. *Microscaler* [26] similarly combines Bayesian optimization (BO) with a heuristic to find the number of instances at which a microservice meets its SLA. Production systems are more conservative: Google's *Autopilot* [20] sets resource limits from moving-window statistics of past usage plus a safety margin, optionally choosing among many such window models by their historical cost.

Top-down models are simple in the sense that they require no knowledge of the application's internal structure: a single model maps the configuration to the end-to-end performance. This is also their limitation: replacing a service or changing the topology changes the modeled function itself, so the end-to-end performance must be benchmarked again (Challenge #2). Furthermore, where uncertainty is modeled at all, as in *CherryPick*, it steers the search towards a good configuration but is not converted into a latency guarantee (Challenge #1).

3) Compositional Models: The *bottom-up* alternative predicts the quality of a composition from its constituent services, which has a long tradition in service-oriented computing. Gallotti et al. [9] translate activity diagrams into stochastic models for a probabilistic model checker; the execution time and reliability of each service are annotations supplied at design time. Wu et al. [25] use a hidden Markov model to predict whether a composition of Cloud services will satisfy the requested QoS, and Fanjiang et al. [6] evolve time-series predictors that forecast the QoS of web services. Geebelen et al. [11] come closest to a guarantee: a Petri-net simulation merges the monitored response times of the elementary services into a time series of the composition, and a kernel-based quantile estimator with an online offset correction predicts the quantile named in the SLO, such that the violation frequency converges to the agreed level. None of these works, however, learns QoS as a function of resource allocation, service configuration, and arrival rate. They can assess compositions of services as currently deployed, but not a composition that involves a configuration without observations; likewise, the guarantee of Geebelen et al. holds asymptotically in the number of observations (Challenge #4).

Fluxion [16] is the closest learned counterpart to our work. It trains one model per service (e.g., a deep neural network or a GP) that maps the service's configuration knobs, its observed states, and the latency percentiles of its downstream services to a latency percentile of the service itself. These models are chained into an inference graph that mirrors the service dependencies; after a service is scaled or replaced, only the model of that service is retrained. However, the inference graph propagates point estimates: Fluxion is evaluated by its mean absolute error, and its authors note that prediction errors accumulate along the graph in a way that is not trivial to derive analytically. A predicted P_{90} can therefore err in either direction (Challenge #1), and the output does not reveal any uncertainty about whether a service model was queried at a configuration it has never seen (Challenge #4).

D. Summary

In summary, analytical models compose rigorously but need known parameters (i.e., access to the source code); top-down learned models support opaque microservices by handling them as black boxes, but they are only valid for the service topologies measured; and existing compositional models propagate predictions without any uncertainty. *Pegasus* (our approach) combines the strengths of these groups: it learns the execution time distribution of each black-box service from local observations, including the epistemic uncertainty for unseen configurations, and composes per-service models into a probabilistic bound on the end-to-end latency.

III. Problem Definition

TODO: Also 50% autocompleted; I would shorten the descriptions and simplify the structure.

A. System Model

We model an application as a service composition S structured as a Directed Acyclic Graph (DAG) over a set of microservices $V = \{s_1, s_2, \ldots, s_K\}$, where directed edges $E \subseteq V \times V$ represent the paths along which items (e.g., requests or video frames) are passed on. For a sequential pipeline, this simplifies to $S = \{s_1 \to s_2 \to \cdots \to s_K\}$ with $K = |S|$ services.

Services. Each service $s_i \in V$ has a configuration $x_i = (r_i, c_i)$, where

- $r_i \in \mathcal{R}_i$ are its resource allocations (e.g., CPU quota, memory limit), and
- $c_i \in \mathcal{C}_i$ are its software configuration knobs (e.g., batch size, model resolution, number of workers).

A service processes one item at a time in the order of arrival; items that arrive while the service is busy wait in its queue. The *execution time* Y_i of s_i is the time (in seconds) from the start to the end of processing one item. Due to runtime variability (e.g., thread scheduling, input size), Y_i is a random variable whose unknown distribution $P_{Y_i|x_i}$ depends on the configuration of the service, but not on the composition in which the service runs. The *latency* of an item at s_i is its waiting time in the queue plus its execution time, $W_i = Q_i + Y_i$.

For each service, empirical evidence is available only as a sparse dataset of execution times observed at N_i configurations, $\mathcal{D}_i = \{(x_i^{(j)}, y_i^{(j)})\}_{j=1}^{N_i}$, collected while the service ran in isolation or within other compositions. Large regions of the configuration space $\mathcal{R}_i \times \mathcal{C}_i$ remain unobserved.

Workload. Items enter the composition at its first service according to an *external arrival process*, which we describe by the gap T (in seconds) between two consecutive arrivals: its mean defines the arrival rate $\lambda = 1/\mathbb{E}[T]$ (items per second), and its squared coefficient of variation $C_a^2 = \mathrm{Var}(T)/\mathbb{E}[T]^2$ the variability of the arrivals. The workload is a property of the application and not of an individual service; an item that leaves a service immediately enters the next one, so every later service receives the departures of its predecessor.

B. Problem Formulation

Let D_S denote the end-to-end latency of an item in the composition S under the configuration vector $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, \ldots, x_K)$, i.e., the time from its external arrival until it leaves the last service. Given a maximum permissible violation probability $\epsilon \in (0, 1)$ specified in an SLO, a latency bound d_S must satisfy

$$\mathbb{P}\left(D_S > d_S\right) \leq \epsilon, \tag{1}$$

which means that d_S is an upper bound on the $(1-\epsilon)$ quantile of the end-to-end latency.

Because the execution-time distributions are only known through models learned from $\mathcal{D}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{D}_K$, Eq. (1) cannot be asserted with certainty. A *Probabilistic Performance Guarantee* (PPG) therefore has two parameters: the violation probability ϵ, which covers the variability between items, and a confidence level $c \in (0, 1)$, which covers the uncertainty of the learned models. A PPG is a latency bound $d_S(\mathbf{x}, \epsilon, c)$ for which Eq. (1) holds with confidence c.

Problem Statement. Given a composition S, a configuration vector $\mathbf{x}$, an external arrival process, a violation probability ϵ, and a confidence level c, derive the PPG $d_S(\mathbf{x}, \epsilon, c)$ in a *zero-shot manner*, i.e., purely from the per-service datasets $\{\mathcal{D}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{D}_K\}$ and without any end-to-end measurement of S. The bound should be as tight as possible, since every unit of slack translates into over-provisioned resources.

C. Foundational Assumptions

To compose performance bounds across black-box services without end-to-end measurements, our framework operates under the following assumptions:

1) *Performance Isolation:* Services run in isolated execution environments (e.g., containers with strict CPU quotas and memory limits), so the execution time of a service is not affected by co-located services.
2) *Single-Server FIFO Services:* Each service processes one item at a time in the order of arrival, has an unbounded queue, and passes a finished item on immediately. Internal parallelism (e.g., the number of workers) is a configuration knob that changes the execution time, but not this queueing discipline.
3) *Load-Independent Execution Times:* The distribution of the execution time Y_i depends only on the configuration x_i; it depends neither on the arrival process nor on the services before s_i, and the execution times of different items at s_i are independent. This is what allows execution times observed in isolation, or in a different composition, to be reused for an unseen composition.
4) *Gaussian Execution Times:* The execution time of an item is modeled as Gaussian, $Y_i \sim \mathcal{N}(m_i, \sigma_i^2)$, with a mean m_i and a standard deviation σ_i that depend on x_i. This yields the closed-form Moment Generating Function (MGF)

$$M_{Y_i}(\theta) = \mathbb{E}\left[e^{\theta Y_i}\right] = \exp\left(\theta\, m_i + \frac{\theta^2}{2}\,\sigma_i^2\right), \quad \theta > 0, \tag{2}$$

on which all bounds of the framework are built. Section VI-B5 evaluates services with heavier tails.
5) *Renewal Arrivals:* The gaps T between external arrivals are independent, identically distributed, and independent of the execution times, and their Laplace transform $\mathbb{E}[e^{-\theta T}]$ is known. This covers, for instance, Poisson arrivals, periodic arrivals with jitter, and gamma-distributed gaps of any C_a^2.
6) *Arrivals Inside the Composition:* The framework does not model the departure process of a service explicitly. A service that is not the first of the composition is bounded as if it received the external arrival process, refined by the minimum spacing that its predecessor enforces between two departures (Section IV-B). This is conservative when the external arrivals are at least as variable as the execution times, as with Poisson arrivals; for nearly periodic arrivals combined with highly variable execution times and high utilization, the departures of a service can be burstier than the external arrivals.

   TODO: Decide after the prototype: keep this assumption, or replace it with a proven bound on the departures (looser).
7) *Feed-Forward Topology:* Compositions are DAGs without cycles. We present the framework for sequential pipelines.

   TODO: DAGs (trees, diamond, fan-out) will be integrated together with the evaluation.
8) *Calibrated Service Models:* The predictive distribution of each learned service model is calibrated, i.e., the true mean execution time of a service lies below the c-quantile that its model predicts for that mean with probability c. The confidence level of a PPG refers to this distribution.

Independence between the execution times of an item at *different* services is not assumed in general; it is only required by one of the two composition variants (Section IV-C).

IV. Pegasus Framework

TODO: Way too long. Shorten especially the intro, but also the subsections, and try to remove some equations.

Given a pipeline S, our methodology derives a Probabilistic Performance Guarantee (PPG) for S. Such a PPG characterizes the performance of a service or service composition together with its inherent runtime variability and the uncertainty resulting from limited empirical evidence. Conceptually, a PPG can be established for individual services (i.e., a single-service pipeline with $|S| = 1$); these local bounds are then composed into end-to-end performance guarantees for multi-service pipelines. Notably, a PPG does not prescribe any optimization objective or algorithm. Instead, it provides a fundamental performance guarantee that enables downstream frameworks to optimize for objectives such as latency, throughput, or cost.

Our methodology consists of three main steps, as depicted in Figure 1: (1) learning a probabilistic model of the execution time of each individual service from empirical observations, (2) deriving a latency bound for each service from its model and the workload, and (3) composing these bounds into a PPG

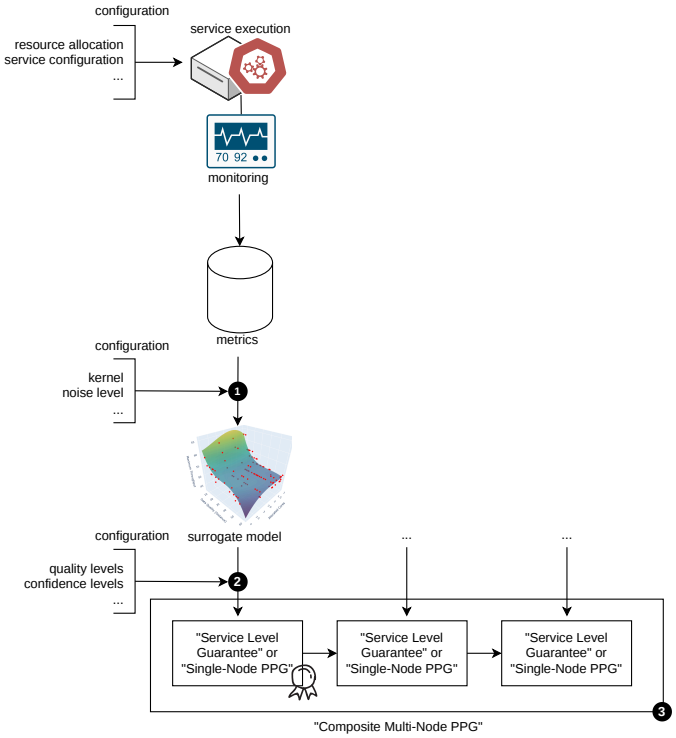


Fig. 1: High-level overview of our three-step methodology for creating end-to-end performance guarantees of arbitrary service composition and configurations: ❶ we model service behavior through a surrogate function, ❷ we extract probabilistic performance guarantees (PPGs) around individual services, and ❸ we calculate the expected performance levels across service compositions by concatenating their PPGs.

for the complete service pipeline. The first step is the only one that requires data, and it only requires data of the individual services. Everything that depends on the composition, i.e., which services follow each other and how many items arrive, enters analytically in the second and third step. This separation is what makes the guarantee available for compositions that were never executed.

A. Learning

The first step trains, for each service s_i, a probabilistic model that predicts the execution time Y_i of an item from the configuration x_i of the service. Two constraints apply to this step: (1) the scaling behavior of services is rarely linear [2], e.g., performance saturates after providing sufficient RAM, while increasing parallelism can actually degrade performance due to scheduling overhead; and (2) services live in containers, whose source code can rarely be analyzed to make assumptions about their functional behavior. Gaussian Processes (GPs) satisfy both constraints, as they are non-parametric and do not impose a structure on the learned function.

We train one GP per service on its dataset $\mathcal{D}_i$, with a Matérn-5/2 kernel and an additive noise term. For a configuration x_i, which may be unobserved, the GP provides three quantities:

- the predicted mean execution time $\mu_i(x_i)$;
- the *epistemic* standard deviation $\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}(x_i)$, i.e., the uncertainty of the model about the mean execution time at x_i, which is large far away from the observed configurations and shrinks with more data; and
- the *aleatoric* standard deviation $\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}(x_i)$, i.e., the scatter of the execution times of individual items around their mean, which is a property of the service and does not shrink with more data.

The following two steps treat these two kinds of uncertainty differently. In the remainder of this section, we omit the argument x_i where it is clear from the context.

The number of observations per service is small in our setting, so we use exact GP inference; its cost is cubic in the number of observations N_i. For services that accumulate large amounts of operational data, the exact GP can be replaced by a sparse approximation (e.g., inducing-point methods) without changing the following steps, which only rely on the three quantities above.

B. Service Bounds

The second step turns the model of a service into a bound on its latency $W_i = Q_i + Y_i$ under a given workload: a value $d_i(\epsilon)$ that the latency of an item exceeds with probability at most ϵ. Unlike the execution time, the latency includes the waiting time Q_i in the queue of the service, and therefore depends on how many items arrive.

Pessimistic Execution-Time Model. The two kinds of uncertainty act differently on a queue. The aleatoric scatter is independent from item to item, so over a busy period of many items it partly averages out. The epistemic error does not: if the model underestimates the mean execution time by 5 ms, *every* item at that configuration takes 5 ms longer, and the work of a busy period of 100 items grows by 500 ms. Adding both variances into the variance of a single item would treat this shared error as if it averaged out, and would underestimate the queue. We therefore let the epistemic uncertainty shift the mean, and keep only the aleatoric uncertainty as the variance per item:

$$\mu_i^+ = \mu_i + z_c\,\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}, \qquad Y_i \sim \mathcal{N}\big(\mu_i^+,\, \sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2\big)\,, \tag{3}$$

where z_c is the c-quantile of the standard normal distribution (e.g., $z_c \approx 1.64$ for $c = 0.95$). According to the model, the true mean execution time lies below the *pessimistic mean* μ_i^+ with probability c; this is where the confidence level of the PPG enters. With Eq. (2), the MGF of the execution time is $M_i(\theta) = \exp(\theta\mu_i^+ + \frac{\theta^2}{2}\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2)$.

Waiting Time. The waiting time of an item at a FIFO service is the largest backlog of work that the items before it left behind. For a service that receives arrivals with independent gaps T, Kingman's martingale bound [15] states that this backlog has an exponentially decaying tail,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(Q_i > w\right) \le e^{-\theta_i^* w}, \qquad \theta_i^* = \sup\left\{\theta > 0 : M_i(\theta)\,\mathbb{E}\big[e^{-\theta T}\big] \le 1\right\}. \tag{4}$$

The *decay rate* θ_i^* (in $1/\mathrm{s}$) combines everything that makes a queue long: it decreases with a larger mean execution time,

with a larger variance of the execution time, with a higher arrival rate, and with more variable arrivals. For Poisson arrivals at rate λ, for instance, $\mathbb{E}[e^{-\theta T}] = \lambda/(\lambda+\theta)$. If no $\theta > 0$ satisfies the condition, the service counts as overloaded and has no finite bound. Since the condition is evaluated with the pessimistic mean μ_i^+, this can also happen for a service that is stable but whose mean execution time is not known precisely enough.

Latency. The waiting time of an item depends only on the items before it, and is therefore independent of its own execution time. Combining Eq. (4) with the Gaussian execution time of Eq. (3) gives the tail of the latency in closed form,

$$\mathbb{P}\left(W_i > d\right) \le \bar{\Phi}\left(\frac{d-\mu_i^+}{\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}}\right) + e^{-\theta_i^*(d-\mu_i^+)+\frac{1}{2}(\theta_i^*\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i})^2}\,\Phi\left(\frac{d-\mu_i^+-\theta_i^*\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2}{\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}}\right), \quad (5)$$

where Φ is the standard normal distribution function and $\bar{\Phi} = 1-\Phi$. The first term is the probability that the execution time alone exceeds d; the second term accounts for the waiting time. The *service bound* $d_i(\epsilon)$ is the smallest d for which the right-hand side is at most ϵ; the right-hand side decreases in d, so $d_i(\epsilon)$ is found by bisection.

Services Inside a Pipeline. Only the first service of a pipeline receives the external arrivals; every later service s_i receives the departures of its predecessor s_{i-1}. We bound such a service with the external arrival process in Eq. (4) (Assumption 6 in Section III-C), and tighten the bound with a property that holds for every pipeline: s_{i-1} processes one item at a time, so two consecutive departures of s_{i-1} cannot be closer together than one execution time of s_{i-1}. If s_{i-1} is slower than s_i, the service s_i can therefore hardly build up a queue, whatever the external arrival rate is. Applying Kingman's bound to the execution times of s_i against this *minimum spacing* gives a second decay rate,

$$\theta_i^{\mathrm{s}} = \frac{2\left(\mu_{i-1}^- - \mu_i^+\right)}{\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}^2 + \sigma_{\mathrm{al},i-1}^2}, \qquad \mu_{i-1}^- = \mu_{i-1} - z_c\,\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i-1}, \quad (6)$$

which is positive only if s_{i-1} is slower than s_i even when s_{i-1} enters with its *optimistic* mean μ_{i-1}^- (a faster predecessor spaces the items less) and s_i with its pessimistic mean. Both tails bound the same waiting time, so the service bound uses the faster decay, i.e., $\max(\theta_i^*, \theta_i^{\mathrm{s}})$ in place of θ_i^* in Eq. (5). Eq. (6) treats the execution times of consecutive items at the two services as independent.

C. Composition

The third step composes the models of the individual services into the PPG of the pipeline S. We provide two variants, which trade assumptions against tightness and which we both evaluate in Section VI.

Composition per Service (*Pegasus Node*). The end-to-end latency is the sum of the latencies at the K services, $D_S = \sum_{i=1}^K W_i$. An item can only exceed the sum of the service bounds if it exceeds at least one of them. Hence, if every service is bounded at the violation probability ϵ/K,

$$d_S = \sum_{i=1}^K d_i\Big(\frac{\epsilon}{K}\Big) \quad \Rightarrow \quad \mathbb{P}\left(D_S > d_S\right) \le \sum_{i=1}^K \mathbb{P}\left(W_i > d_i\Big(\frac{\epsilon}{K}\Big)\right) \le \epsilon. \quad (7)$$

This union bound requires nothing about how the latencies at different services depend on each other. It therefore remains valid if an item that is slow at one service is also slow at the next one (e.g., a large video frame), and although the queues of consecutive services are coupled. Its price is that every service is bounded further in the tail as the pipeline grows, and that every service pays for its own queue as if it stood alone, apart from the minimum spacing of Eq. (6). Each service bound is one closed formula, so the cost of evaluating d_S grows linearly with K.

Composition per Pipeline (*Pegasus SNC*). Stochastic Network Calculus (SNC) [7] composes the *service* that the nodes offer instead of their bounds: the pipeline is treated as one system that receives the external arrivals once, and what happens between the services is absorbed into the composition. In the MGF domain, the end-to-end latency of a pipeline of FIFO services obeys

$$\mathbb{P}\left(D_S > d\right) \le e^{-\theta d}\prod_{i=1}^K \frac{M_i(\theta)}{1-\rho_i(\theta)}, \qquad \rho_i(\theta) = M_i(\theta)\,\mathbb{E}\left[e^{-\theta T}\right] < 1, \quad (8)$$

for every $\theta > 0$, where each factor is the latency moment of one service: its execution-time MGF, inflated by the queue that the load $\rho_i(\theta)$ causes. Solving for the latency at the violation probability ϵ and choosing the best θ yields

$$d_S = \min_{\theta>0}\ \frac{1}{\theta}\left[\sum_{i=1}^K \ln\frac{M_i(\theta)}{1-\rho_i(\theta)} - \ln\epsilon\right]. \quad (9)$$

In contrast to Eq. (7), the violation probability is not split: the term $-\ln\epsilon$ is paid once for the whole pipeline, which is the "pay bursts only once" property of network calculus. Moreover, Eq. (9) makes no assumption about the arrivals inside the pipeline, so Assumption efasm:internal-arrivals is not needed. In return, a single parameter θ is shared by all services, so one service close to saturation loosens the bound of the whole pipeline, and the product in Eq. (8) requires that the execution times of an item are independent between the services. If they are not, Hölder's inequality restores the validity for any dependence: service s_i enters Eq. (8) with its variance multiplied by an exponent $p_i \ge 1$, where $\sum_i 1/p_i = 1$. This makes the bound looser and its evaluation more expensive, because the exponents are tuned per configuration; we report it as an ablation.

Resulting Guarantee.

Both variants return a latency bound that satisfies Eq. (1) whenever the pessimistic mean of every service lies above its true mean execution time. Each service fulfills this with confidence c, according to its model. For the whole pipeline, all K services must fulfill it simultaneously, which holds with confidence of at least $1-K(1-c)$; choosing the per-service level as $1-(1-c)/K$ would restore the confidence c for the

pipeline, at the price of larger pessimistic means. We apply c per service and report in Section VI how often the resulting bounds cover the measured latency quantile of the pipeline.

TODO: Decide: keep c per service (current implementation) or split it over the services.

Why This Combination. The three steps depend on each other. Point-estimate models (e.g., neural networks or gradient-boosted trees) provide no epistemic uncertainty and thus no pessimistic mean, which is what protects the bound at configurations that were never observed. The GP provides it, and separates it from the scatter between items. Its Gaussian form gives the MGF of Eq. (2) in closed form, and the MGF is exactly the quantity from which both the martingale bound and SNC derive the tail of a queue. As a result, the service bounds and their composition are evaluated from closed-form expressions, without simulating the pipeline and without sampling.

V. Implementation

TODO: Needs some introduction and cutting.

Service Models. Each service model is an exact GP with a Matérn-5/2 kernel and an additive white-noise term, fitted on standardized configurations. The epistemic variance of a prediction is the variance of the latent function, and the aleatoric variance is the fitted noise level.

Training on Run Statistics. A benchmark run of a real service processes many items at one configuration. Instead of a single item per run, we use two statistics of each run as training targets: the mean of its execution times, and their spread, defined as (95th percentile − median) / 1.645, i.e., the standard deviation of a Gaussian with that median and 95th percentile. The mean of a run is a far less noisy observation of the mean execution time than a single item; in turn, it no longer reveals how much single items scatter, so a second GP per service predicts the spread and provides $\sigma_{\mathrm{al},i}$. Both GPs are fitted on the logarithm of their target, because the knobs of a real service act multiplicatively on its execution time (e.g., a larger model at a higher resolution), which becomes additive on the logarithm. The shift of Eq. (3) is then relative, $\mu_i^+ = \mu_i\, e^{z_c \sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}}$ with $\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}$ on the logarithmic scale, where $\sigma_{\mathrm{ep},i}$ also contains the scatter between repeated runs of the same configuration. The predicted spread enters the bounds without a margin of its own.

Evaluating the Bounds. The decay rate θ_i^* of Eq. (4) and the minimum in Eq. (9) are evaluated on a fixed logarithmic grid of θ; any θ below θ_i^* keeps Eq. (4) valid, so the grid can only make a bound larger. The service bound $d_i(\epsilon)$ is found by bisection on Eq. (5) and returns the upper end of the final interval.

Discretization of the Configuration Space. Numerous service knobs could actually be scaled on a fine-grained Integer scale, for example, the scheduled CPU quota is configured in *microseconds*, or the resolution of video frames in *pixel*. Nevertheless, Cloud systems commonly offer only a small set of discretized configurations, around which the performance predictions are more accurate [2]. We hypothesize that the granularity of the discretization might improve the convergence of accurate PPGs, while trading off solution optimality. Not sure if we'd analyze this now.

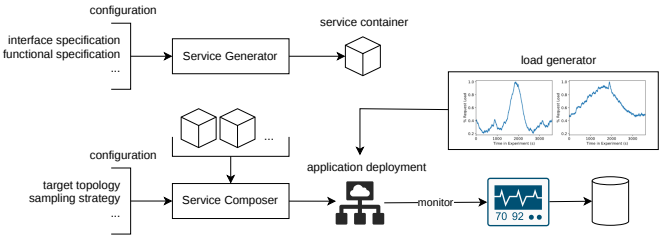


Fig. 2: High-level architecture of the experimental environment: the *service generator* creates containerized services according to a desired interface and functionality; the *service composer* ...

VI. Evaluation

A. Experimental Setup

Service Generation. To evaluate generalization across structural dimensions, we evaluate unseen service configurations, unseen service compositions, and their combination. This requires an ample set of services and service compositions; for this, we combine an existing set of microservices and configuration interfaces from prior work [22] and augment it through LLM-based code generation.

Sampling Strategies. To evaluate the impact of training data collection strategies on bound calibration, empirical observations will be gathered under three *sampling strategies*: (1) uniform random sampling across the configuration space, (2) active learning under different acquisition functions (e.g., uncertainty minimization of value maximization), and (3) exhaustive grid search, which we must prune at some point.

Baselines. We compare *Pegasus* against five baselines that all operate under the same constraint: each method is trained only on observations of the individual services and never on a run of the evaluated composition. Hence, methods produce an end-to-end latency for an *unseen* composition S with $K = |S|$ services, which we compare with the ground truth, i.e., the measured $(1-\epsilon)$ quantile of the end-to-end latency of S. The baselines form three groups, which differ in what they observe per service and in how they account for queueing:

- **Execution-time models without queueing (*GP Sum*, *DNN Sum*):** one model per service predicts the mean and the standard deviation of the execution time from the service configuration; the end-to-end latency is the $(1-\epsilon)$ quantile of the sum of these execution times, assuming that they are Gaussian and independent between services. *GP Sum* uses the same GPs as *Pegasus*, so the two differ only in the composition; *DNN Sum* replaces each GP with a feed-forward neural network that reports the standard deviation of its training residuals. Both ignore the arrival process and thus represent the naive composition of per-service predictions.

  TODO: As in Fluxion [16] we must argue that this is a common method for predicting end-to-end latency.

- **Queueing formula (*Kingman*):** the predicted mean and variance of the GPs enter Kingman's approximation of the mean waiting time in a G/G/1 queue [15], combined with an exponential waiting-time tail [13]. This gives the $(1-\epsilon)$ latency quantile of each service, and the quantiles are added. *Kingman* represents classical queueing analysis on top of a learned model: it accounts for queueing, but it is an approximation and not a bound, and it takes the GP predictions at face value, without a margin for epistemic uncertainty.
- **Learned latency quantiles (*Quantile Union*, *Conformal*):** instead of execution times, these baselines learn the latency of a service under load. Each service is monitored in isolation under the arrival process of the workload, and one GP per service predicts its $(1-\epsilon/K)$ latency quantile from the service configuration; the K predictions are added, which splits the violation budget ϵ over the services as a union bound. This corresponds to the modular learning of latency percentiles in *Fluxion* [16], with every model restricted to data of its own service. *Quantile Union* uses these point predictions directly. *Conformal* adds a split-conformal step: a part of the training configurations is set aside, and each prediction is multiplied by a correction factor calibrated on that part, such that it covers the latency quantile of the service with a chosen confidence. Both need a load test per service and training configuration, whereas *Pegasus* needs execution times only, and both assume that a service receives the same arrival process inside the composition as in isolation.

As a reference, we report an *Oracle*, the union bound over the *measured* $(1-\epsilon/K)$ latency quantiles of the services inside the composition. It uses the ground truth and is therefore not a competitor; it shows the tightest result that any method splitting the budget ϵ over the services can reach, so the remaining distance to a method is caused by its per-service bounds and not by the union bound.

Besides the baselines, we ablate the composition step of *Pegasus* on identical GP models: (1) the union bound over per-service bounds, with Chernoff-based or martingale-based bounds, each with and without propagating the departure process of the preceding service, and (2) the network service curve, with and without Hölder's inequality, which extends its validity to dependent services. Finally, the experiment on fine-tuning with end-to-end samples (Section VI-C1) is the only one that includes baselines trained on runs of the composition itself: the sum of per-service latency quantiles measured inside the composition, and a *Fluxion*-style chain of GPs that passes predicted latency percentiles from one service to the next [16].

B. Coverage and Tightness of Service Bounds

1) Base Case: This will use most of the baselines from above to evaluate the maturity of our ideas vs. existing techniques.

2) Varying Evidence per Service: This makes use of the presented sampling strategies. The services are executed somewhere under an arbitrary service composition that is different from the target composition. We gradually train the PPGs with more of this data and see if this has an impact on the quality of the unseen target composition.

3) Varying Chain Depth: We evaluate how the validity, empirical coverage rate, and tightness of the derived PPGs scale with pipeline depth. By evaluating synthetic and real chains across varying lengths $|S| \in \{1, 2, 5, 10, 20, 50, 100\}$, we assess whether the composed bounds remain sufficiently tight and actionable for downstream optimization without suffering from severe bound degradation.

PROBLEM: We promise DAGs, but in our current state of evaluations we only have chains. This is not enough and we must have some more complex DAGs.

TODO: Before we get Milos' results on the hierarchical application, I can look into synthetic data.

4) Varying Load and Arrival Pattern: Here we will use different arrival pattern (e.g., periodic, random (= Poisson), and batching) and different arrival rates (e.g., diurnal or bursty with custom range). I already explored this once and found that we can characterize each of these arrival processes through the squared coefficient of variation (C_a^2) as defined by

$$C_a^2 = \frac{\mathrm{Var}(X)}{(\mathbb{E}[X])^2} = \frac{\sigma^2}{\mu^2} \tag{10}$$

5) Varying Tail Behaviors: Here I can look at services that have a different tail behavior (e.g., increasingly heavy/light tails) and how this impacts the quality of the guarantee.

6) Varying Percentiles: Optionally, I could also look into different percentile guarantees and show where each method is more/less accurate.

C. Iterative Optimization of Service Bounds

I would integrate this into a use case, where we have to compose increasingly better applications using this method.

1) Fine-Tuning Bounds with E2E Samples: Our focus is giving a rough guarantee *before* deploying it e2e, so this means the best we can do as soon as it goes e2e is to show that our model provides an initial accuracy boost that likely vanishes over time.

2) Inferring Faster Service Compositions: This can go into two directions, first, we can optimize the service configuration according to the model, and second, we can improve the service composition.

For the first one, we can take *Fluxion* [16] (cf. Section 5.1.3) as inspiration, where they also used the model paired with an external optimizer to show how their model enables better performance optimization. They simply compared the different guarantee models (theirs, a plain GP, and a DNN) for coupled with different optimizers; this we can do as well, and it is also a nice cut between the guarantee (our contribution) and the external optimizer.

For the second one, it might be a bit more complex because we have not talked a lot about the composition mechanism, but I would design it like the first one: we assume some composition mechanism that is external to us and we gradually show that by using our guarantees it can create

better service composition. I think that this is the real deal because it repeatedly looks into unseen configurations, but it also the most complex evaluation. In any case, I think that a genetic algorithm could be the best choice here, because it builds a population of potential solutions and then iteratively improves them through sampling. But we do NOT have to include multiple rounds of benchmarking, but only one. The distinction would be:

- **single round**: we build a population of compositions and grade them according to different guarantees (ours vs. baselines). We repeat this step in a genetic algorithm until we have a solution for every guarantee. Then we benchmark these solutions and look at their fitness.
- **multiple round**: as above, but we use the empirical samples we captured from the benchmark and run the genetic algorithm (planning) and benchmarking again and again until we converge to a satisfying result. This we keep for future work at NSDI hehe

VII. Discussion

@Víctor most likely

A. Limitations

Gaussian priors for Service Behavior. The performance of distributed systems is known to show heavy-tailed behavior, e.g., during garbage collection phases. While it is not possible to model such behavior through a Gaussian prior, Pegasus can still be extended to support such distributions: instead of using the MGF function to derive performance bounds,

Sampling from Evaluation Rounds. The idea was that we can drastically simplify experiments by not propagating decisions (e.g., *where* to explore) back to the services, but instead use the grading function to sample from all conducted runs. Given the coverage of the solution space, we can bound the inaccuracy this creates by finding the largest distance between two points, or a point and the parameter bounds.

VIII. Conclusion & Future Work

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POTENTIAL APPENDIX

- Proof why we need to model latency directly and not capacity. Plot the noise and the shapiro-wilk normality test.
- Proof of the dependence/independence between frames services in the queue.
- List of the services and their states and configuration knobs in more detail. This can be clusters of service types, as for *Fluxion* in [16].
- Description of the code artifact, or at least a pointer to the extended description in the README there.
- Analysis of different GP kernels.